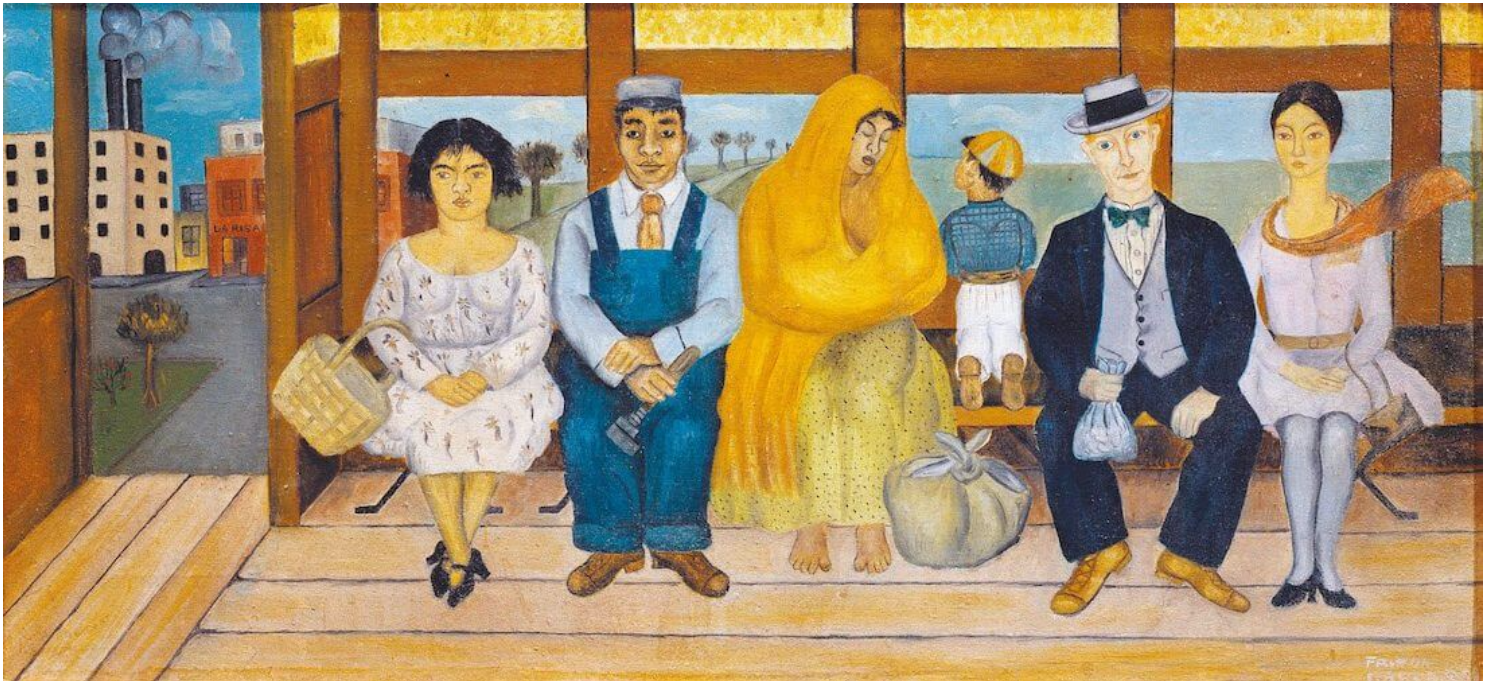


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH  
*of Los Angeles*

*Illuminated: A Cinematic Journey to Deeper Spirituality*

*Meaning in the Ordinary*

*January 26th, 2025*



*Frida Kahlo - The Bus, 1929*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020  
Telephone 213.385.1341 – [www.FCCLA.org](http://www.FCCLA.org)

## **The Gathering of the People**

*First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~*

### **Organ Prelude Concert**

**Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence**

Improvisation on TALLIS' CANON and ST. DENIO

Psalm 42 (Alfred Fedak)

- Chorale
- Duo
- Canon
- Fughetta
- Improvisation

A Window To The Past (John Williams, adapted for Organ by Christoph Bull)

Danza (Manuel de Falla, adapted for Organ by Christoph Bull)

Prelude in C Major (Johann Christian Heinrich Rinck)

Fugue in C Major, BWV 545 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

### **Chiming of the Hour**

#### **Welcome**

**Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack**

#### **Words of Gathering**

**Greta Langenberg & Danielle Vigent**

In this Season of Epiphany we remember  
that no road takes us to a sure place.  
If we have been there before,  
what we remember of it  
may have changed, people moved away,  
buildings altered.  
What we remember  
holds us in the moment of time  
we last experienced the reality of the place.

But even should the walls remain in place,  
the trees around be strong and yet as broad,  
the people unchanged from when we last arrived –  
the place of our hearts will know new terrain  
and we, who carry it with us,  
will see with different eyes.

*May we be open to what our eyes tell us of our lives  
in the ordinary places well-known and loved,  
and in new lands, new discoveries, new places  
of the heart.*

*We ask all of this, as those who walk a common road.*

[adpt/gvosper]

*Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering*

**\*Hymn of Gathering**

*From Wisdom Emerging*

ST. DENIO

From Wisdom emerging, we fashion a space  
For people converging in safety and grace,  
To shelter the freedom of one and of all  
In Love without border or boundary or wall.

Faith's journey reclaiming, we blaze a new trail  
With others, exclaiming: "Let justice prevail!"  
Rejecting worn paths that oppress and mislead,  
We walk in community, cherished and freed!

Forever exploring, we seek to learn more  
Of Wisdom's outpouring, of Love's open door.  
Amazed at the mysteries and graces we find,  
We joyfully share them with all humankind.

The future progressing, we move through its change,  
Old systems redressing, new patterns arrange;  
Protecting all the freedoms with every new choice,  
We follow the Spirit and raise our clear voice!

**\*Prayer of Awareness**

**Rev. Tanaka Pack**

Holy One,  
we awake to this new day  
with all of its possibilities,  
its uncertainties,  
its many faces,  
and its underlying mystery.

Help us to be able –  
in your strength –  
to move through this day,  
letting go of all that takes  
our attention away from  
the miracles around us  
so that,  
when we meet our neighbor  
or encounter a stranger,  
we will recognize  
your face, and our own.  
*Amen and Amen!*

[adapt/ An Iona Prayer Book]

**\*Introit**

*"Swimming To The Other Side"*  
Cathedral Choir

PAT HUMPHRIES, arr. DAVID HARRIS

**\*The Lord's Prayer**

**Danielle Vigent**

*Our [God], who art in heaven,  
hallowed be thy Name,  
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,  
on earth as it is in heaven.  
Give us this day our daily bread,  
and forgive us our debts,  
as we forgive our debtors.  
And lead us not into temptation,  
but deliver us from evil.  
For thine is the kingdom,  
and the power, and the glory,  
forever.  
Amen.*

**\*Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,  
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.  
World without end, Amen, Amen.

**\*Passing of the Peace**

**Rev. Michael Lehman**

May our time together renew our hope.  
May the stories we share refresh our courage.  
May the songs we sing lift our spirits.  
May the words we speak invigorate us.  
May the touch of hands, the sound of laughter,  
the sight of faces new and familiar,  
restore us in faith. [CODame]

May the peace of God be with you.  
*And also with you.*

*You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.*

**Please be seated**

**Reading from Our Religious Tradition**

**Greta Langenberg & Danielle Vigent**

*from the Gospel of John, Chapter 2*

This is the Gospel of Grace.  
*Thanks be to God!*

**Prayers with the People**

**Rev. Tanaka Pack**

**Invitation to Silence and Prayer**

*Silence*

## Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One,  
you have given us  
so many ways to see / feel / know  
the miracles that reside in our ordinary lives.  
Yet, we sometimes miss the beauty of the ordinary  
as it rises to a previously inaccessible view,  
even as it stands firm in the cold sweat of our fear,  
even as it wells up in someone else's need,  
and we act far beyond our preconceived limitations.

Eternal One,  
we are created by these ordinary miracles,  
this urgent pull toward life.  
We weigh its blessings as gift,  
and cast curses upon its challenges.  
It is by these we are able to define ourselves,  
judging our responses to the world and each other  
against an invisible code.

Gracious One,  
would that we had more confidence  
in our ability to make the right choices,  
to do the right thing,  
to be strong enough to face the outcomes of life.  
Then we could live without fear  
and celebrate the sweetness encased in each moment.

*May we find in this day  
an awareness of the freedom we are given,  
to know life unshackled from fear,  
and embrace the possibilities of the present,  
with every breath we take.*

*We pray as those who share a common journey.  
Amen and Amen.*

## Meditation Anthem

"God's Got The Whole World"  
Cathedral Choir

MARK A. MILLER

## Sermon

*Meaning in the Ordinary*

Rev. Lehman

## The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Lehman

In time beyond our dreaming God hovered over the water,  
and was revealed in fire and storm and precious law.  
Likewise, humanity in this God's likeness evolved on this earth,  
along with earth's minerals and waters, flowers and fruits,  
and living creatures of grace and beauty!  
*We offer this, our thanks and praise.*

In this season of Epiphany,  
we also remember the love made manifest in the  
stories of Jesus of Nazareth.  
In ordinary moments and beautiful miracles  
we recall the words Jesus spoke  
to call forth love, care, and respect for one another.  
*We remember...*

### **Breaking of the Bread and Pouring of the Fruit of the Vine**

Long ago, our tradition reminds us, Jesus took bread,  
offered thanks for it, and broke it:  
saying, 'This bread is broken, as my body will be'.

Jesus handed it to his friends, and invited them to eat:  
saying, 'Remember all that I have been to you'.  
*We remember...*

Long ago, our tradition also says, Jesus poured a cup of the fruit of the vine,  
offered thanks for it, and gave it to their friends:  
saying, 'This cup is poured out, as my life will be.  
As you drink, give thanks for all I have given'.

Bread... the very stuff of life.  
The Cup... fruit of the vine and celebration.

### **Prayer of Blessing**

Eternal One,  
in our headlong rush through life  
we are often unaware of the ordinary realities  
of the world that exists beyond  
our most cursory glance.

All of us thirst for healing,  
for wholeness,  
for holiness.

May we find at this table,  
the food that will bring  
refreshment to our souls  
and, in that gift, may we  
find the ability to let go,  
and share the life we have been given  
with others.

*Amen and Amen.*

### **Sharing of the Bread and the Cup**

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

## Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

*At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at [fccla.org/give](http://fccla.org/give). Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.*

## Offertory

"Winter Is Past"

JOSEPH N. RUBENSTEIN

Laude

## \*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,  
let the Creator's praise arise!  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Your name shall sound and praises soar  
till suns shall rise and set no more.  
Alleluia! Alleluia!  
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

## \*Prayer of Offering

Greta Langenberg

Holy One, as we leave this sacred moment in time,  
may we be wholly present in our own lives,  
ready to be surprised by the wonder  
of each ordinary moment,  
as we live and move and have our being,  
enveloped in your peace.

May the earth be warm under our feet,  
may the rain bring the gentle flowers of the earth to surround us,  
and may the wind blow as the breath of the Spirit before us,  
both this day and forever more.

*Amen and Amen!*

*Please be seated*

## Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

## Words for the Journey

Rev. Lehman

Let us go in faith to ponder in our hearts  
the mystery and the wonder of this season...

If, here, you have found freedom,  
*take it with you into the world.*  
If you have found comfort,  
*go and share it with others.*  
If you have dreamed dreams,  
*help one another, that they may come true.*  
If you have known love and unity,  
*share it with a bruised and hurting world.*

[LBellamy/C3E, 2009]

May the freshness of the dawn enliven your spirits.  
May the rising of the sun enlighten your minds.  
May the noon-tide of the day warm your hearts.  
And may the sunset clothe us all with restfulness. [WWallace/wb]  
*Amen and Amen!*

## Choral Response

"Irish Blessing"  
Cathedral Choir

KAY MUTERT

## \*Hymn for the Journey

*Let There Be Light, O God of Hosts*

TALLIS' CANON

Let there be light, O God of hosts! Let there be wisdom on the earth!  
Let broad humanity have birth! Let there be deeds instead of boasts.

Within our passionate hearts instill the calm that ends all strain and strife;  
Make us your ministers of life; stop us from deeds that curse and kill.

Give us the peace of senses clear to know our neighbors' good our own;  
To hope and suffer not alone, bonded in love that conquers fear.

Let woe and waste of warfare cease, that useful labor yet may build  
Its homes with love and laughter filled! God, teach your humble children peace.

*Please be seated for the Postlude*

## Postlude

**Dr. Christoph Bull**, *Organist-in-Residence*

Moderato in C Major (Johann Christian Heinrich Rinck) and Improvisation

### Inside The Music

"One of the first things that I did when we moved into our home in 2020 was to plant a lemon tree. I needed to witness its beauty and healthy newness. Within the first year a branch from another tree fell and took off its most prominent limb, a pocket gopher chewed at its roots, and I realized that our gray water system was keeping it too wet. By the time I moved it to another location it had only a few leaves and no fruit. Moving it compromised the root system, and, of course, the gopher lives in that part of the yard too, but it made the journey. As lemon trees go, it's had a difficult life. Today, though, it's very first lemon is ready to pick. To me, that lemon contains a deep, lasting, hopeful beauty in its yellowing skin. I have witnessed a fellow living being struggle for years. The tree, however, hasn't seemed to particularly care about what anyone else needed it to be. It simply engaged life determinedly. The main character of "Paterson" as well as Jesus in the first miracle story, reflect that same resolve. In both cases, the protagonists demonstrate abilities that others want them to take credit for and share, but they have other ways of considering their place in the world. Pat Humphries shares this sentiment in "Swimming To The Other Side." We all have different ways of experiencing the world, she says, but we are equally caught up together in the same flow of living. Mark Miller's "God's Got The Whole World" offers a similar insight. In his reimagining of the Negro Spiritual by a similar name, Miller invites us to hear a well-known message with fresh ears. Miller chooses gender-neutral language for God as a way of acknowledging God's universality, and as a way of honoring the beloved members of our community who are teaching us that gender binary paradigms dissolve the vastness of the divine. Miller also greatly simplifies the music, creating a contained prayer of hope. It is a musical reminder that we can't possibly understand the expansiveness of creation, but we can connect with our own divine place within the world. Joe Rubenstein is a friend and a composer whose music we've enjoyed here several times. "Winter is Past" is his most recent choral piece that he shared with me last week. The Song of



Solomon text that he chose feels important right now. While encouraging their loved ones to realize the beauty that surrounds them, the poet isn't asking them to forget what they have endured. The text acknowledges that hard times have been among us, are even still here. It also reminds us that life is here to be lived. By opening ourselves to the ordinary, we can find the extraordinary. Joe's music illuminates the words with sonic gestures. The hard rains of the poet's winter fall slowly and settle through key change, and melody. The notes go from high to low in an ever slowing pattern. The growing flowers are accompanied by canonic entrances that move upward, reaching from the earth to the sun. The birds sing "la, la, la." Unlike the lemon tree, humans have the trait of making meaning of things that happen. Contemporary neuroscience has shown us that meaning is more often predictive. That is, our brains decide what is going to happen and what it means before anything actually happens, and before we consciously realize we've made that decision. Poems like this one remind us that sensory awareness, our understanding of this moment right now through our senses, is our only real counterbalance to the predictive meanings that we live by. As we learn to thrive in our new environments, simple artistic statements like the ones today bring us into the present. They surround us with the potential to ease our predictive loops and notice the divine in this ordinary moment. For what is truly extraordinary but this moment right now?" ~ Dr. David Harris